

Private Wealth Governance in a Wild Twenty-First Century

Gary Bedford — 18th Annual Rocky Mountain Economic Summit — Bronze Buffalo Club & Resort, Victor, Idaho — July 16, 2026

Summary

Gary Bedford closed the Rocky Mountain Economic Summit with an extended meditation built around the bronze buffalo skull mounted above the stage. He argued that every talk given that day, on capital, water, nuclear power, the Federal Reserve, tariffs, childhood and AI, and the health of the republic, was a glimpse of a single animal — the runaway acceleration of human knowledge since 1970, measured in population, wealth, debt, and ecological strain. Drawing on thinkers from Thomas Sowell to Joel Mokyr to the Genesis story of the tree of knowledge, Bedford framed useful knowledge as inherently free and inherently dangerous, arriving faster than the wisdom needed to govern it. He proposed that private wealth, not government alone, must help rebuild a culture capable of pairing knowledge with wisdom, and he closed by naming [the Whitestone Foundation](#) and its [Wild Globalization Project](#) as the vehicle built for exactly that work. The room gave him a standing ovation.

Transcript

Listen. Can you hear them? Can you feel the thunder of sixty million buffalo who once roamed the ground beneath us, a wild animal nation? But then something came over the mountain, and they were gone. Look at the bronze buffalo skull above us. It's looking at us. It's a witness. We sit humbly in its presence.

Now look around our gathering. We're some of the most successful people in the country. We may look back at today and realize it is one of the most momentous days of our lives, because we heard tough, blood-and-guts, real, challenging, but also promising messages. Deep wounds have surfaced. We sit with the buffalo. Here's the question, the turning point, the hunt that has been on the table today. In our twenty-first century, are we the buffalo, or are we the thing that came over the mountain, or are we both?

Here's what came over the mountain, just since 1970, and let me remind you that the etymological root of economy and ecology is the same root. It's *oikos*, which in Greek signifies home, household, the management of home and household. Just since 1970, by the way, when Scott and I graduated from high school, human population has doubled from four to eight billion. I'm not good at clickers, but human productivity exploded from four to a hundred trillion. Government debt exploded from thirty percent to a

hundred percent of GDP. Private wealth jumped from ten to five hundred trillion. And by 1970, humans had flown from Kitty Hawk to the moon. Next stop, Mars.

Here's the buffalo nation on the run, the *oikos*, the ecology. The Living Planet Index reports that fifty to seventy percent of vertebrate species are at risk. Six of nine environmental boundary risks may have been breached. The Cold War is hot again, and in January of this year the Doomsday Clock was reset to eighty-five seconds to midnight. It's never been closer. We're riding a rocket, and it's not certain that anyone is flying it. Thought leaders McNeill and Engelke call this phenomenon the Great Acceleration. Their point is chilling: no creature has ever multiplied and built and burned the way human beings have in the last seventy-five years. Government and elected leaders are panicked, without knowing why or what to do. Are they the hunted? Our neighbors back home, especially our kids, are just plain scared.

It's wild. That's the point. So what's the strategy for what's coming over the mountain? That is why we're here. Jaws. We all know the scene. Sheriff Brody is chumming off the back of the boat when the great white rises out of the water. Brody, cigarette hanging from his lips, turns and says the only honest thing a man can say in that moment: "You're going to need a bigger boat." And that's been the whole assignment today.

Everyone who spoke gave us a glimpse of the animal. Our job now is to figure out if we're going to need a bigger boat, bigger imaginations, bigger ideas, bigger nerves to hunt what's going on. That's what Ben Abbott was talking about with a new paradigm for water. Fourteen talks, one animal, one turning point. When Paul Ryan talked capital and economy, and Megan Greene talked supply shocks, and Bob Gay spoke of conscience in business, the same animal. When John Wagner asked why nuclear, why now, or Ben Abbott taught water, same animal. When Paul McCulley told us where the Fed sits, and John Silvia updated us on housing and tariffs, same animal. As Attorney General Derek Brown defends our children's innocence in the age of AI, and Martin Frey gave kids hope and the victory of living, lean on that one, because it's our kids' hearts and souls that are at stake, same animal. Governor Herbert talked about the republic's great risks, same animal. Finally, we heard from [a special guest speaker], the message that might matter most: the mortal risks to freedom, to speech, to learning, and to enterprise. Same animal. Every one of them was hunting the same wild animal. My job now is to get us sharpening our tools, our focus, talking and teaming up together. That's the key. Together. One animal. What are we hunting?

My proposition to you today is wild civilization. All of us together, we are now the great white in the water. For three hundred thousand years, *Homo sapiens* have survived

critical turning points: wild predators, ice ages, global winters, famines, horrific plagues. And for most of those three hundred thousand years, humans solved problems in tribes and clans and small groups, groups like our own, under the tent at the foot of the Tetons. Then, between twelve and five thousand years ago, the earth warmed, the *oikos*, the ice pulled back, and humans started settling into larger and larger groups. Agriculture and urbanization, the two most daunting challenges of our twenty-first century, they got rolling.

So here's the question for us. As things got bigger, with more people running around, did we start to look to big governments to run things? Big Roman Empire, big Asian dynasties, big laws, big elections, big budgets, bigger debt. But wait, two thousand years ago, didn't one man and his disciples turn governance, turn civilization? Is something changing with public governance, but also with what our Wild Globalization Project calls private wealth governance, that's five hundred trillion dollars on the table. In the twentieth century, big governments ignited the great wars, and then citizens fought and died and saved the world from the great white, from itself. Big government reset the massive U.S. economy to build the tools of war, and then a hundred and twenty-five thousand scientists and engineers innovated, and the Manhattan Project finished it.

But we must ask this too: is big government working today? Are Medicare, Medicaid, and Social Security working? We know the answer, and four hundred Federal Reserve economists know it too. Is Europe or the Middle East working? How are the U.S. and China getting along? Now, I'm not standing here with the former Speaker of the House, two governors, and an attorney general present to say that government is the enemy. It is not. I'm here to ask all of us to consider the question: where does genius come from?

The American Republic was conceived by a handful of private citizens, lawyers, farmers, and one printer. Every one of them technically a lawbreaker. They were a small group, not unlike ourselves. They were wrestling for the nation's new soul and spirit. Today, genius emerges from tents like ours, or workshops, or dorm rooms, or garages. Microsoft and Google, a dorm room. Apple and Turning Point USA, a garage. The Wright brothers' bicycle workshop launched us to the moon. Higgins boats landed freedom on Omaha Beach. And Einstein cracked the universe open on his lunch break at a patent office.

So this afternoon, I propose we turn our tent into a garage. And here's what we have to chew on: what can that five hundred trillion dollars do to solve problems, and maybe pick up some of the slack for big government? And if we're out in the wilderness hunting wild civilization, do we want to kill it, or each other? With the clock at eighty-five

seconds, should we hunt and kill the great white, or should we save it? Should we live with it? Should we love it? Do we wish our ancestors had found a way to live with and love the buffalo? The Lakota, who lived around here, called the buffalo Tatanka, which signifies generosity and self-sacrifice. Tatanka was a sacred gift from the Great Spirit.

Warning, though: we've moved into the wilderness. We need to fall in love with the great white, with the buffalo, with ourselves, Democrats, Republicans, Socialists, Buddhists, Hindus, Muslims, Christians, Jews, Jains, and everything in between. We have to fall in love with wild civilization, not chaos. And what is the wild? In the Wild Globalization Project, we think of it as six forces: the planet, or ecology; people, which is demographics and culture; technology; economy, or power and wealth; and finally, knowledge. All tangled and yanking on each other at once, stronger and faster every year. We call that complexity a quantum entanglement. This is where wild civilization lives. And of those six, one is the master key: knowledge. Every other force only moves when somebody learns something new. Every miracle in history is, more often than not, knowledge showing up on time.

But what is knowledge? How does it work? How are we working knowledge, and how is knowledge working us? And more precisely, what the 2025 Nobel economist Joel Mokyr calls useful knowledge is why we're here. To be clear, what came over the mountain, what took the buffalo and the buffalo people from the wilderness, was our own human culture of free, but also dangerously unrestrained, useful knowledge. Let me repeat that: what came over the mountain was our very culture of free, dangerously unrestrained, useful knowledge.

As the great Thomas Sowell reminds us, every human generation for three hundred thousand years has had the same natural resources at their disposal. "The difference between their lives and our own," he writes, "is the knowledge that people could bring to bear on those resources, and the knowledge used today." We learned to free useful knowledge from redirection today: nuclear power, water, housing, tariffs, war, capital, AI, our republic. Charlie's dream. Fourteen talks, one answer: wild and free, and curious and courageous knowledge.

It's no coincidence that Western civilization's Bible tells the story of creation and quickly moves into the wilderness with the story of Adam and Eve and the fruit of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. And that mysterious serpent, is the serpent there because the knowledge of good and evil comes with catches, with serpentine strings attached? That is, with freedom, value, miracles, power, paradigm shifts, and with wisdom, or not?

First, freedom. Knowledge, the philosopher and theologian Bernard Lonergan reminds us, is unrestrained, which means wondrously and wildly, but also dangerously and often violently, free. Remember, we got thrown out of the garden. We're free. We're knowledge orphans, as Derek Brown emphasized a few moments ago. We're free agents. We're wild. Our project calls it the free, unrestrained human creative, destructive value response. Not capitalism, not socialism, but something that's absolutely the case for every human on the planet: the unrestrained human creative, destructive value response. So ideas like capitalism and socialism, or Democrat and Republican, just aren't big enough boats to float what's going on. It's free and unrestrained human knowledge that creates miracles and catastrophes and everything in between, and therein lies our challenge.

Second, value. Knowledge is the force behind the creation and destruction of human value. The economy, is it the stone, bronze, iron, fossil fuel, internet, information, or AI age? Or has it always been simply the age of the latest useful knowledge? Miracles and power.

Third, miracles and power. The discovery of the universe's secrets, like Newton's laws of motion or Einstein's relativity, gives us miracles. Albert Einstein said there are only two ways to live: as though nothing is a miracle, or as though everything is. And we can add to that: knowledge is godlike, powerful. Sixty million buffalo, powerful. Einstein's theory gave us atomic energy, and twelve thousand nuclear weapons in our closets. We first got kicked out of the garden, and we've now taken over the garden. But do we know what to do with it?

Finally, serpentine strings. There's one more catch. The physicist Geoffrey West teaches us about the laws of scale, which is what we're living through right now, laws that apply to nature's creatures but also to human population, to our cities and resources. For example, every week a million people are moving into cities and crowding out nature's resources. Is anyone aware of that? A million people a week are moving into cities. Welcome to the wild twenty-first century.

All the statistics we quoted above, population explosion, markets, debt, threats to the natural world, are tracking one scale law in particular: exponential growth. Run anything on free, unrestrained growth, and you eventually hit what West calls finite-time singularities. The useful knowledge paradigm of the day can run out of energy, reach its limit, wear out. We can run out of free knowledge. We almost killed off the whales, until kerosene came along. Then Ben Abbott confirmed this with his own change of water paradigm.

But here's what has to happen next: wild human thinking has to dig up the next big idea, the next paradigm shift. Stone to bronze. Gunpowder to nuclear. The 1960s Asian famine to the 1970s Green Revolution. The 1970s energy crisis to multi-directional fracturing and drilling and abundance. Turing's thinking machine to AI. But are we prepared for the new idea, the shift? Was anyone ready for Hiroshima, or for AI? Did we prepare our kids for social media, for the thing that came over the mountain? Knowledge is always ahead of us, ahead of our moral and ethical sense, our common sense.

Let me add this: in a highly technological world like our own, the paradigm shifts, the miracles, have to keep coming faster. The thousand-year gap between the Stone Age and the Bronze Age is now twenty years between the information age and the AI age. We're running on a treadmill that keeps speeding up, and we have to keep leaping to the faster ones, forever.

Finally, wisdom. And here's the serpent's big catch: every new knowledge paradigm requires a new wisdom paradigm. This is what we're learning from Derek Brown, that our free and practical wisdom, our common sense, has to keep up, has to keep getting stronger. Wild miracles need new wild miracles of wisdom. Welcome to the wild.

So here's my close. We start with miracles, but we need to end up with wisdom. Knowledge and wisdom both live in the entanglement, everything, everywhere, at once. Knowledge and ideas are no longer just evolving from physical nature; they're emerging from metaphysical hypernature, suddenly, overnight. It's information, imagination, innovation, and invention. Knowledge happens suddenly, it shocks and awes the world, and wisdom has to try to keep up.

The uncomfortable question I want to leave in the room is simple: where is knowledge and wisdom going to come from?

First, we have to fall in love with the problem. Uri Levine, the Israeli technologist and entrepreneur, tells us we have to fall in love with the problem, acknowledge it, live it, track it along the beaten path of public governance and education, but be bold, go off trail into the wilderness with wild entrepreneurs and private actors.

Second, we have to bring compassion to the hunt. Try to realize that human knowledge is not out of control or crazy. The great white is just hungry, wild. It will eat any and all of us. Still, we're not lost. Surely the twentieth century looks crazy: world wars, pandemics, famines. And Lord knows our twenty-first century is fighting bitterly over everything. Still, we're here. Something is working. Knowledge is not crazy. It's wild. It's

not supposed to be easy. It's a fight for everyone, every soul and creature and wild space on the planet.

Third, we have to learn wildly. Some call it the scientific method; we might call it wild learning, learning to sniff out and nudge knowledge and wisdom to where they're probably already headed anyway. As Michael Crichton reminds us, "Science is not consensus. Consensus is not science. Science is one investigator working and bushwhacking ideas and hunches that can be verified by peers." Science and wisdom are not a consensus. Learning and wisdom are more like arm wrestling, a wild logic.

Fourth, let the thought leaders be free. Incessantly encourage and protect our leaders and thought leaders, our entrepreneurs, our dreamers, to rethink and reinvent knowledge and wisdom. Free thinking, free speech, free debate, free enterprise, freedom. We have to be free because the wild is free. We have to track and bushwhack freedom, because that's how the wild works.

Fifth, critical thinking, home. We have to keep building and rebuilding our knowledge and wisdom home. Perhaps we could call it Bob Gay's Cathedral of Wisdom, our inside-the-box schools and universities, but also our outside-the-box wild learning, our streets or our back roads. Teach hardware things like math and science, but also teach software things like history, great literature, philosophy, and religion. Bushwhack wisdom and critical thinking. And here's the credo: information is not knowledge, knowledge is not wisdom, and wisdom without information and knowledge is empty ideology.

And finally, we have to teach our kids. We have to build wealth cultures. Wealth is not money, it's not capital. Wealth is useful knowledge and wisdom, and we can't just teach wealth and wisdom, we must build generational cultures of knowledge and wisdom. Get our families wealth to live on. Get it into the wilderness. Let it live in the world. Turn our kids on to wealth and knowledge and wisdom.

The Wild Globalization Project that I'm building lives inside a foundation called Whitestone, and the whole reason Whitestone has existed for twenty years is to incessantly think and act on this exact problem. Not to defend the old knowledge home of universities, but to constantly rebuild it out in the open for the age of wild globalization and AI, to put the thinking and the thinkers back where this century could actually reach them. We believe that knowledge is free, so our website has everything on it free, including mywildglobalization.com. This is not a pitch, it's an invitation. If that kind of thing turns out to be your shark, come find me and our team tonight.

Finally, let me conclude. We must ask ourselves how we're different from the buffalo, from Tatanka. And here's the difference: the buffalo couldn't see the thing coming over the mountain. They weren't wild enough. They got hit with something wilder than they were. That's exactly what it means to be wild. The buffalo never got a vote. But we do. We have a voice, a vote, a choice. We can see it coming. We can name the animal, and we can decide what to do about it. And the word for that ability to respond is freedom. Freedom, as in the power to make a miracle on purpose. That's what it means to be human in the twenty-first century. Freedom is the one miracle that makes all the other miracles possible.

So in a few minutes, we're going to walk out of this tent into one of the most beautiful valleys God ever made. There's a fire out there, and a band that flew all the way from Australia, and the dinner Chef Bo has been building while we were sitting here pondering the fate of the species. Let's go enjoy every minute of it. We've earned it. But somewhere between the second drink and the last song, I'm hoping each one of us finds someone in the room, in the tent, and the two of us start a conversation about falling in love with your shark, about hanging out with your kids in your garage, about your miracle. Because the clock is at eighty-five seconds, and the buffalo are still right here under our feet, listening for what we do.

Let's not be the buffalo.

May the wild be with you. Thank you.